AMERICAN PLACES

U.S. Treasury Building Washington, D.C.

In the early years of the nation, the Department of the Treasury was housed in Philadelphia. When the capital moved to Washington, D.C., so did the Treasury. After two Treasury Buildings burned down, construction on a final structure began in 1836—and this time, its architects made it fireproof. A statue of Alexander Hamilton stands before the south entrance of the building, shown here.



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1.2 Cabinet and Courts

Imagine trying to play a game of soccer or basketball without any teammates. It wouldn't work. George Washington didn't guide the new country alone, either. He gathered an A-list of team members to help him.

MAIN IDEA The first order of business for George Washington and Congress was to assemble a presidential Cabinet and create a court system.

ASSEMBLING A TEAM

In the summer of 1789, Congress created the Departments of State, Treasury, and War as part of the executive branch. Washington appointed the department heads, called secretaries, and they formed his Cabinet.

To oversee relations with other countries, Washington chose Thomas Jefferson as Secretary of State. As Secretary of War, former general Henry Knox would see to the country's defense. And to manage the government's money, Washington selected Alexander Hamilton as Secretary of the Treasury. Congress also created the office of the **attorney general**, whose primary role was to represent the United States before the Supreme Court. He would be a member of Washington's Cabinet, but unlike the others, he would not head an executive department. Edmund Randolph served as the first attorney general.

The president called his Cabinet secretaries together for regular meetings. However, you might be surprised to learn that Vice President John Adams was *not* invited to these meetings. The vice president soon realized the limitations of his position. "My country," he wrote, "has in its wisdom contrived [designed] for me the most insignificant office that ever the invention of man contrived or his imagination conceived."

THE HIGHEST COURT IN THE LAND

In addition to building the Cabinet, Washington and Congress created a court system. The Constitution established a Supreme Court as the nation's highest court. But it left the question of how many justices would sit on the Court to Congress and didn't specify what its powers would be. So, in 1789, Congress passed the Federal Judiciary Act. It called for the Supreme Court to have six justices—one **Chief Justice** and five associate justices. Today, eight associate justices sit on the court. The Chief Justice presides over the judicial branch of the U.S. government as well as over the Supreme Court itself. John Jay became the country's first Chief Justice.

The act created the world's first dual-court system, with responsibilities split between state and federal courts. Federal courts handled interstate and international cases, disputes regarding the U.S. Constitution, and civil and criminal cases relating to federal laws. State courts dealt with cases involving state laws and civil disputes within states. The act also created lower, or less powerful, federal courts.

The federal government established executive departments and a working system of courts, but more challenges lay in store. For one thing, there was the small matter of a very large war debt to be paid.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What departments made up Washington's Cabinet?
2. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** What do the Cabinet departments suggest about what was important to the new government?
3. **MAKE INFERENCES** Why do you think the Federal Judiciary Act created both state and federal courts?

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